

A classical H^2 obstruction, read as supply-chain inventory: the inventory gerbe and its band

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Abstract

A supply chain, abstracted to a small category $\mathcal{C}$, carries inventory as local stock-data glued along logistics operations. When charts are compared by *equality* of counts, consistency is a degree-one class $[\theta_R] \in H^1(N(\mathcal{C}); R)$ (companion note). Here we refine the comparison to *isomorphism of stock-states*: lots are fungible, so charts match only up to a relabelling group $K = \text{Aut}(F)$, and the gluing data becomes an $\text{Aut}F$ -gerbe over the nerve $N(\mathcal{C})$. The resulting obstruction is *not new mathematics*: it is the classical central-extension lifting class on $N(\mathcal{C})$, read for the first time as an inventory invariant. We make this precise and honest. The obstruction is *staged* after Giraud: a global inventory exists iff *two* obstructions vanish — first the *band* $\beta \in H^1(N(\mathcal{C}); \text{Out}(\text{Aut}F))$, a genuinely nonabelian datum, and then the *gerbe class* $[\mathfrak{g}] \in H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z(\text{Aut}F))$ (Corollary 17). The gerbe class vanishes on every 1-dimensional (free / DAG / tree) chain, and is nonzero already on a single reversible loop $B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$ — but only for a *nonabelian* fibre with nontrivial centre; the minimal witness is a four-lot ring, $\text{Aut}F = D_4$ (Theorem 20). It is logically independent of the Zappa–Szép weld $[\omega]$, not because the two live over different coefficients — on $B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$ they can lie in the *same* group and even coincide — but because $[\mathfrak{g}]$ depends on the inventory datum and $[\omega]$ does not (Theorem 22). Finally, both strata are invisible to plain fungibility: $\text{Aut}F = S_n$ is centreless *and* complete for $n \geq 3$, $n \neq 6$, so the two-tier phenomenon is a feature of *gauge/torsor-structured* stock, not of interchangeable commodities (Theorem 25). The result places inventory consistency as a fourth distinct H^2 home on $\text{DCont} \simeq \text{Cat}$, distinguished by its *input datum*.

1 Introduction

Composition is where correctness is won or lost, and inventory is where the price is paid. When two delivery routes reconverge on the same stock-keeping unit, when stock is moved and merged and counted again downstream, the question is always whether the local records glue to one consistent global record. When they do not, the failure has an economic name: phantom inventory, a reconciliation that never closes, a write-off. A compositional theory of supply chains earns its keep by telling you *which* such failures can occur and *where* they live.

The categorical model is standard. A supply chain — nodes as objects, admissible logistics operations as morphisms — is a small category $\mathcal{C}$; equivalently, by Ahman and Uustalu [1], a

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directed container. Its nerve $N(\mathcal{C})$ is the simplicial set whose n -simplices are composable strings of operations, and the cohomology of $N(\mathcal{C})$ is the natural home for obstructions to gluing local data along $\mathcal{C}$.

In a companion note [2] we asked when inventory, recorded as counts transported along operations, glues consistently. Writing the inventory as a resource presheaf R on $\mathcal{C}$, the answer was clean: consistency is the vanishing of a *degree-one* class $[\theta_R] \in H^1(N(\mathcal{C}); R)$, the route-reconvergence discrepancy of stock counts, and this class is logically independent of the Zappa–Szép weld obstruction $[\omega] \in H^2(\mathrm{Sk}_{\mathcal{C}}; \mathcal{D})$ that governs whether $\mathcal{C}$ factors as a product of two chains at all [3, 4]. That note flagged one refinement as the natural next question, and the present note answers it.

The gap. Equality of counts is the wrong comparison when lots are *fungible*. Two pallets of the same grade are interchangeable; a local stock-state is a labelled configuration, but the labels carry no information, so two charts should be regarded as matching when they are *isomorphic*, not when they are literally equal. Each inventory fibre F then carries a *relabelling group* $K := \mathrm{Aut}(F)$, and comparison of local charts is canonical only up to K . Gluing up-to-isomorphism is not a gluing-of-sets problem; it is a gluing-of-*stacks* problem — a gerbe over $N(\mathcal{C})$. The companion note anticipated that the obstruction would rise to H^2 , but left three questions open. Does the obstruction equal $[\omega]$, which also lives in H^2 ? What exactly must vanish for a global inventory to exist? For which fibres is the phenomenon even nonvacuous?

What is new, and what is not. We settle all three. The honest framing matters, and we state it at the outset: the obstruction is *classical mathematics*. It is the central-extension lifting class of Schreier and Eilenberg–MacLane, specialised to the nerve $N(\mathcal{C})$ and pulled back along the relabelling transport; for small categories this is the extension theory of Ho [9] and Wells [10], classified cohomologically by Baues–Wirsching [11]. An arXiv search (October 2026) found no prior reading of it as an inventory invariant, so the *application* is new; the *mathematics* is not. We pitch it accordingly — a classical obstruction, newly read as inventory — and the work of the note is to get the reading exactly right.

The results. Fix a fibre F with relabelling group $K = \mathrm{Aut}(F)$, centre $Z := Z(K)$, inner group $\mathrm{Inn}K = K/Z$, and outer group $\mathrm{Out}K$. Two sequences organise everything:

$$\begin{aligned} 1 \longrightarrow Z \longrightarrow K \xrightarrow{\pi} \mathrm{Inn}K \longrightarrow 1 & \quad (\text{central extension of } K) \quad (\star) \\ 1 \rightarrow Z \rightarrow K \xrightarrow{\mathrm{conj}} \mathrm{Aut}K \xrightarrow{q} \mathrm{Out}K \rightarrow 1, \quad \mathrm{Inn}K = \ker q & \quad (\text{inner/outer tower}) \quad (\star\star) \end{aligned}$$

The gluing datum of fungible inventory is an $\mathrm{Aut}F$ -gerbe over $N(\mathcal{C})$ whose structure group is K . Classifying it is *staged*, exactly as in Giraud’s non-abelian cohomology: the *band* $\beta \in H^1(N(\mathcal{C}); \mathrm{Out}K)$ — the outer part of the relabelling transport — must vanish before the degree-two class is even defined, and then that class $[\mathfrak{g}] \in H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z)$ is the lifting obstruction of $(\star)$. Our results are:

Theorem 1 (Rectification $\Leftrightarrow$ vanishing; Theorem 11). *Once the band is trivial, a global inventory — a strict functor $\mathcal{C} \rightarrow BK$ realising the up-to-iso gluing — exists if and only if $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$ in $H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z)$. This is the Schreier / Eilenberg–MacLane central-extension lifting criterion, specialised to $N(\mathcal{C})$.*

Corollary 2 (The staged obstruction; Corollary 17). *A global inventory exists if and only if both strata vanish: (i) the band $\beta = 0 \in H^1(N(\mathcal{C}); \mathrm{Out}K)$ and (ii) the gerbe class $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0 \in H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z)$, the latter well-defined only once (i) holds.*

Theorem 3 (Degree-genuineness; Theorem 20). *If $|N(\mathcal{C})|$ is homotopy equivalent to a 1-dimensional complex — in particular if $\mathcal{C}$ is the free category on a quiver (a tree-like or DAG chain) — then $H^{\geq 2}(N(\mathcal{C}); Z) = 0$, so $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$ for every fibre. There is a minimal one-node witness, $\mathcal{C} = B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$ with the fibre a four-lot ring ($K = \text{Aut} F = D_4$), for which $[\mathfrak{g}] \neq 0$.*

Theorem 4 (Independence from the weld; Theorem 22). *$[\mathfrak{g}] \in H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z)$ and the Zappa–Szép weld $[\omega] \in H^2(\text{Sk}_{\mathcal{C}}; \mathcal{D})$ are logically independent: over the family of pairs (inventory datum, weld datum) on a fixed $\mathcal{C}$, all four vanishing patterns occur. The mechanism is not a difference of coefficients — on $\mathcal{C} = B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$ the two classes can lie in the same group $H^2(\mathbb{Z}/2; \mathbb{Z}/2)$ and even coincide — but a difference of input data: $[\mathfrak{g}]$ depends on the inventory fibre, $[\omega]$ does not.*

Theorem 5 (Nonvacuousness; Theorem 25). *$[\mathfrak{g}]$ can be nonzero only if K is nonabelian with nontrivial centre ($\text{Inn} K \neq 1$ and $Z \neq 1$); the minimal such K are D_4 and Q_8 . For F a bare n -element set of indistinguishable lots, $\text{Aut} F = S_n$ is abelian or centreless for every n and complete (so $\text{Out} = 1$) for $n \geq 3$, $n \neq 6$: fungible stock carries neither obstruction. The two-tier phenomenon is a feature of gauge/torsor-structured stock, not of interchangeable commodities.*

The main results are visible by page two. The picture is a *two-tier* obstruction with a *staged* degree-two tier:

tier	charts compared by	obstruction	coefficients, degree
1	equality of counts	$[\theta_R]$	R (resource group), H^1
2a (band)	iso of states, outer part	β	$\text{Out}(\text{Aut} F)$ (nonabelian), H^1
2b (gerbe)	iso of states, central part	$[\mathfrak{g}]$	$Z(\text{Aut} F)$ (fibre centre), H^2
(precond.)	does $\mathcal{C}$ factor at all	$[\omega]$	$\mathcal{D}$ (weld vertex groups), H^2

The method. One classical fact, specialised to $N(\mathcal{C})$, does the work. Comparing inventory charts across an operation transports the relabelling group K by an automorphism, functorial only up to inner automorphism; its outer reduction is the band β (Lemma 15), and $\beta = 0$ iff the transport is inner-valued up to relabelling (Theorem 16). When $\beta = 0$ the transport descends to a functor $\rho : \mathcal{C} \rightarrow B(\text{Inn} K)$, and the gerbe is its *gerbe of lifts* through $(\star)$: choosing set-section lifts $T_f = s(\rho_f)$ exhibits a Z -valued 2-cocycle γ whose class is $[\mathfrak{g}]$ (§3). Rectification then reads as trivialising γ by a central 1-cochain — an elementary coboundary computation (Theorem 11). The remaining theorems are a simplicial computation on the nerve (Theorem 20), a comparison with explicit witnesses (Theorem 22), and the classical automorphism arithmetic of S_n (Theorem 25).

Consequences and placement. Three points up front. (i) The refinement is *exactly* one categorical level: equality-gluing is H^1 , iso-gluing is H^2 , with a nonabelian H^1 band in between that must vanish first. (ii) Because $[\mathfrak{g}]$ and $[\omega]$ can share a group, the temptation to identify “inventory is inconsistent up to relabelling” with “the chain fails to weld” is a genuine trap — they can even be equal — and only the *input datum* separates them; Theorem 22 makes this precise. (iii) The nonvacuousness criterion sharpens the applications story: the economically relevant tier-two case is not plain fungibility of many interchangeable units (centreless, complete S_n) but *gauge-valued* stock — allocation defined up to a group action — whose automorphism group is nonabelian with a centre. Within the Kodamai program, $[\mathfrak{g}]$ is the *fourth* distinct H^2 home on $\text{DCont} \simeq \text{Cat}$, after the Zappa–Szép holonomy, Ferri prunability, and the Baues–Wirsching class H^2_{Cat} ; it is distinguished from them by its *input datum* (the inventory fibre), not by a coefficient-system discriminator.

Outline. Section 2 recalls supply chains as directed containers, the two sequences $(\star)$ – $(\star\star)$, and the Giraud strata we use. Section 3 defines the object as the gerbe of lifts and exhibits its cocycle. Section 4 proves the rectification criterion (Theorem A) and identifies it as classical. Section 5 proves the band criterion and the staged corollary (the band boundary). Section 6 proves degree-genuineness (Theorem B). Section 7 proves independence from the weld (Theorem C). Section 8 proves the nonvacuousness criterion and the fungibility dichotomy (Theorem D). Section 9 states the scope, the honest open problem (coupled strata), and the two-tier bottom line.

Note on this revision. This note corrects the version of 9 October 2026 (commit 9eb0941) following Rick’s referee report of 10 October. The corrections are substantive and we state them openly rather than paper over them: the earlier degree-genuineness hypothesis (“homotopy 1-truncated”) was false and is replaced by “homotopy equivalent to a 1-complex” (§6); the earlier minimal witness ($K = \mathbb{Z}/2$) was wrong — a bare set carries no tier-two class — and is replaced by the four-lot ring $K = D_4$ (§6, 8); the earlier “different coefficients” explanation of independence was false and is replaced by the input-data mechanism (§7); and the band, previously hypothesised away, is now settled (§5). The gerbe cocycle is renamed γ to free the symbol ω for the weld.

2 Preliminaries

The section records only what the proofs use. A reader fluent in directed containers and non-abelian cohomology can skim to Section 3.

2.1 Supply chains as directed containers and their nerve

A supply chain is modelled as a small category $\mathcal{C}$: objects are nodes (warehouses, plants, stock locations), morphisms are admissible logistics operations, composition is sequencing. By Ahman–Uustalu [1] a small category is the same thing as a directed container, so the model lives natively in the container program.

The *nerve* $N(\mathcal{C})$ is the simplicial set with $N(\mathcal{C})_0 = \text{Ob}\mathcal{C}$, $N(\mathcal{C})_1 = \text{Hom}\mathcal{C}$, and $N(\mathcal{C})_n$ the set of composable strings $c_0 \xrightarrow{f_1} c_1 \rightarrow \cdots \xrightarrow{f_n} c_n$. For an abelian coefficient group A with (here) trivial $\mathcal{C}$ -action, $H^\bullet(N(\mathcal{C}); A)$ is the cohomology of the normalised cochain complex with the usual alternating-face differential. Two facts are used below:

- For a one-object category $\mathcal{C} = BG$ (a group G viewed as a category), $N(BG)$ is the standard classifying space and $H^\bullet(N(BG); A) = H^\bullet(G; A)$ is group cohomology.
- If $|N(\mathcal{C})|$ is homotopy equivalent to a 1-dimensional CW complex then $H^{\geq 2}(N(\mathcal{C}); A) = 0$. This holds for the free category $F(Q)$ on a quiver Q , whose classifying space is homotopy equivalent to the graph $|Q|$.

We emphasise the second fact in its correct form: it is *homotopy 1-dimensionality*, not homotopy 1-truncatedness, that forces $H^{\geq 2} = 0$. A $K(\pi, 1)$ such as $B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$ is 1-truncated yet has $H^{\geq 2} \neq 0$; see Remark 21.

2.2 Inventory fibres and the two sequences

An *inventory fibre* F is the local type of a stock-state at a node: a configuration of lots. Fungibility means the labels carry no information, so the relevant symmetry is the *relabelling group*

$$K := \text{Aut}(F), \quad Z := Z(K) \text{ (centre)}, \quad \text{Inn}K := K/Z \text{ (inner group)},$$

fitting into the central extension $(\star)$. We write $\pi : K \rightarrow \text{Inn}K$ for the quotient and reserve $s : \text{Inn}K \rightarrow K$ for a chosen *set-section* with $s(e) = e$ (not a homomorphism in general). The band lives in the outer group $\text{Out}K$ of the inner/outer tower $(\star\star)$; $\text{Inn}K = \ker q \cong K/Z$ is the image of conjugation.

2.3 The gerbe, its band, and the Giraud strata

Comparing two inventory trivialisations of the same fibre across an operation f identifies them only up to the relabelling group K , i.e. transports K by an *automorphism* $\alpha_f \in \text{Aut}K$. Re-trivialising a chart conjugates the transport, so α is functorial only up to inner automorphisms: $\alpha_{gf} = \iota \cdot \alpha_g \alpha_f$ for some $\iota \in \text{Inn}K$. Collecting the local trivialisations into a stack makes the gluing datum an $\text{Aut}F$ -gerbe over $N(\mathcal{C})$: a stack of groupoids locally equivalent to $B(\text{Aut}F)$ (Giraud [7], III; Breen [8] for the bitorsor/cocycle presentation). A *global inventory* is a global section realised on the nose — a strict functor $\mathcal{C} \rightarrow BK$ whose transition data glue strictly.

Giraud's classification of a G -gerbe over a base X (for us $G = \text{Aut}F = K$, $X = N(\mathcal{C})$) factors into *three strata*:

stratum	datum	invariant	home
1 (unbanded)	structure 2-group cocycle	$\pi_0 \cong H^1(X; \text{Aut} K)$	nonabelian H^1
2 (band)	outer transport $\rho := q \circ \alpha$	$\beta := [\rho] \in H^1(X; \text{Out}K)$	nonabelian H^1
3 (fixed band)	centre cocycle	$[\mathbf{g}] \in H^2(X; Z)_\beta$	abelian H^2

We work the classification at strata 2 and 3, which is where a *strict global section* lives: stratum 1 concerns which 2-group presents the gerbe, which for a fixed fibre F and constant relabelling group is already pinned. The **band** β must vanish before the degree-two coefficients Z are untwisted and $[\mathbf{g}]$ is defined; this staging is the content of Section 5. For stratum 3 we need only one classical fact, imported rather than re-derived: an abelian-band gerbe over $N(\mathcal{C})$ with band A (trivial $\mathcal{C}$ -action) is classified by $H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); A)$, the trivial class being the one admitting a global section (Giraud [7], III). Everything else — the cocycle, its class, the rectification algebra, the band criterion — we compute in place.

Conventions for nonabelian H^1 . For a group Q (constant coefficients) a *cocycle* is a functor $\mathcal{C} \rightarrow BQ$, i.e. a map $\gamma : \text{Mor}\mathcal{C} \rightarrow Q$ with $\gamma(gf) = \gamma(g)\gamma(f)$, $\gamma(\text{id}) = e$; two cocycles are *cohomologous* iff related by an object-relabelling $\lambda : \text{Ob}\mathcal{C} \rightarrow Q$, $\gamma'(f : x \rightarrow y) = \lambda(y)\gamma(f)\lambda(x)^{-1}$. Then $H^1(N(\mathcal{C}); Q) := Z^1/\sim$, pointed by $\gamma \equiv e$; $[\gamma] = 0$ means $\gamma \sim e$. For Q abelian this is ordinary simplicial H^1 ; for Q nonabelian it is a pointed set.

3 The inventory gerbe as the gerbe of lifts

We define the object directly as the *gerbe of lifts* of the inner transport through the central extension $(\star)$. This is the honest construction: it makes transparent that the degree-two class is extra lifting data pulled back along the transport, not a number computed from the fibre F in isolation.

Definition 6 (The inventory gerbe). Fix a fibre F with $K = \text{Aut}F$ and suppose the band is trivial ($\beta = 0$; Section 5), so the relabelling transport is inner-valued up to relabelling and descends to a functor

$$\rho : \mathcal{C} \longrightarrow B(\text{Inn}K), \quad \text{Inn}K = K/Z.$$

The *inventory gerbe* is the Z -gerbe of lifts of ρ through π in $(\star)$: its local objects are lifts of ρ_f to K , and its band is the centre Z with trivial $\mathcal{C}$ -action. A *global inventory* is a global section — a strict functor $\mathcal{C} \rightarrow BK$ lifting ρ .

Remark 7 (Why the gerbe of lifts, and not a bare K -gerbe). It is tempting to call the object a “ K -gerbe with trivial band” and invoke the band formalism to reduce its coefficients to Z . That is imprecise: a K -gerbe with trivial band and the Z -gerbe of lifts of ρ are *different* objects — for $\rho = \text{id}$ the inner form $\mathbf{Tors}(\text{Inn}K)$ has a global section while the Z -gerbe of lifts does not — so “global section $\Leftrightarrow [\mathfrak{g}] = 0$ ” depends on which one is meant. We therefore *define* the object as the gerbe of lifts (equivalently, as the $\text{AUT}(F)$ -pseudofunctor of Remark 10), and no separate band-is-the-centre lemma is needed: the coefficients are Z by construction.

3.1 The cocycle

Definition 8 (Section cocycle). Choose set-section lifts $T_f := s(\rho_f) \in K$ for each operation f , with $T_{\text{id}} = e$. Because both $T_g T_f$ and T_{gf} map to $\rho_g \rho_f = \rho_{gf}$ under π , their ratio lands in $\ker \pi = Z$:

$$T_g T_f = \gamma(g, f) \cdot T_{gf}, \quad \gamma(g, f) \in Z. \quad (\dagger)$$

Thus $\gamma = \rho^*$ (extension 2-cocycle of $(\star)$) is a normalised 2-cochain on $N(\mathcal{C})$ valued in Z .

Lemma 9 (γ is a cocycle and $[\mathfrak{g}]$ is well-defined). *Associativity of multiplication in K , together with the centrality of Z (so conjugation acts trivially on the values of γ), gives the normalised 2-cocycle identity*

$$\gamma(h, g) \gamma(hg, f) = \gamma(g, f) \gamma(h, gf), \quad \text{i.e. } \delta\gamma = 0,$$

and changing the set-section s replaces γ by a cohomologous cochain. Hence $[\mathfrak{g}] := \rho^[\star] = [\gamma] \in H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z)$ is well-defined.*

Proof. Expand $T_h(T_g T_f) = (T_h T_g) T_f$ using $(\dagger)$ three times and cancel the common T_{hgf} ; centrality lets the Z -values commute past the T ’s. Replacing s by s' sets $T'_f = c_f T_f$ with $c_f \in Z$, and $(\dagger)$ gives $\gamma'(g, f) = \gamma(g, f) (\delta c)(g, f)$. $\square$

Remark 10 (Face 1 is definitional: $[\mathfrak{g}]$ is a k -invariant, not a number from F). When K is abelian, $\text{Inn}K = 1$, ρ is trivial, and the gerbe of lifts of Definition 6 is *trivial*: $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$. So an abelian fibre carries no inventory class by this construction. The abelian K -gerbes presented by a free 2-cocycle $\gamma \in Z^2(N(\mathcal{C}); K)$ — the “abelian face” of the earlier version — are therefore *not* determined by F : a pseudofunctor into the 1-category BK is just a functor and carries no 2-cell data, so a nonzero class is extra input. Precisely, the datum is a pseudofunctor into the automorphism 2-group $\text{AUT}(F)$ (with $\pi_1 = \text{Out}K$, $\pi_2 = Z$), and $[\mathfrak{g}]$ is its k -invariant [13, 14]. We record this honestly: Face 1 is the *definition* of a classification datum, not a computation from the fibre. The constructive, inventory-driven class is the gerbe of lifts of Definition 6, which requires a *nonabelian* K (so that ρ can be nontrivial) — as Theorem 25 makes precise.

4 Rectification is the vanishing of $[\mathfrak{g}]$

Theorem 11 (Theorem A). *With the band trivial, a global inventory — a strict functor $\mathcal{C} \rightarrow BK$ lifting ρ — exists if and only if $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$ in $H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z)$, where $Z = Z(\text{Aut}F)$.*

Proof. Re-choosing the lift at each operation f multiplies T_f by an element $c_f \in Z$ (it moves T_f within its Z -torsor of lifts of ρ_f). A candidate global inventory is a 1-cochain $c : \text{Mor}\mathcal{C} \rightarrow Z$ producing new transitions $T'_f = c_f T_f$, and strictness is $T'_{gf} = T'_g T'_f$. Using $(\dagger)$ and centrality,

$$c_{gf} T_{gf} = T'_{gf} \stackrel{!}{=} T'_g T'_f = c_g c_f T_g T_f = c_g c_f \gamma(g, f) T_{gf},$$

which holds iff $\gamma(g, f) = c_{gf} c_g^{-1} c_f^{-1} = (\delta c^{-1})(g, f)$. Hence a global inventory exists iff γ is a Z -coboundary, i.e. iff $[\mathbf{g}] = [\gamma] = 0$. $\square$

Remark 12 (This is the classical lifting criterion). Theorem 11 is *not* new. It is the Schreier / Eilenberg–MacLane criterion for lifting a map into a quotient $\text{Inn}K$ through a central extension $(\star)$, here pulled back along ρ and specialised to the simplicial site $N(\mathcal{C})$: for small categories this is the extension theory of Ho [9] and Wells [10], with the cohomological classification of Baues–Wirsching [11]. We present it as a specialisation so read, not as a theorem of this note; the contribution is the *reading* of ρ , Z , and $[\mathbf{g}]$ as inventory transport, fibre centre, and rectification obstruction.

Remark 13 (Concrete check: D_4 and Q_8). Take $\mathcal{C} = B((\mathbb{Z}/2)^2)$ and $K \in \{D_4, Q_8\}$, each with $Z = \mathbb{Z}/2$, $\text{Inn}K = (\mathbb{Z}/2)^2$, and $\rho = \text{id}$ (the inner transport is the full inner group). A strict lift would be a splitting homomorphism $(\mathbb{Z}/2)^2 \rightarrow K$ of $(\star)$; none exists, since K is nonabelian while $(\mathbb{Z}/2)^2$ is abelian. Correspondingly the section-cocycle γ of $(\dagger)$ is not a coboundary, so $[\mathbf{g}] \neq 0$ and rectification fails. The non-splitting and $[\mathbf{g}] \neq 0$ are confirmed by brute-force enumeration over $\mathbb{F}_2$ (`inventory_gerbe_h2.py`; the reduced-nerve H^2 engine of the Lean witness file [6]).

5 The band, and the staged obstruction

The earlier version hypothesised the band away. We now settle it, following Giraud’s three-stage factorisation over the simplicial site $N(\mathcal{C})$. This is the program’s first genuinely *nonabelian* content: the band lives in H^1 with the nonabelian coefficient *group* $\text{Out}K$.

Definition 14 (Band). The *band* (lien) of the inventory gerbe is the outer reduction of the relabelling transport,

$$\rho_{\text{out}} := q \circ \alpha : \text{Mor}\mathcal{C} \longrightarrow \text{Out}K,$$

where $\alpha : \text{Mor}\mathcal{C} \rightarrow \text{Aut}K$ is the transport (functorial up to inner) and q is as in $(\star\star)$. Its class is $\beta := [\rho_{\text{out}}] \in H^1(N(\mathcal{C}); \text{Out}K)$.

Lemma 15 (The band is always a strict cocycle). ρ_{out} is a genuine functor $\mathcal{C} \rightarrow B(\text{Out}K)$, so β is well-defined regardless of the up-to-inner slack in α .

Proof. Write $\alpha_{gf} = \iota \cdot \alpha_g \alpha_f$ with $\iota \in \text{Inn}K = \ker q$. Apply q : $\rho_{\text{out}}(gf) = q(\iota) q(\alpha_g) q(\alpha_f) = \rho_{\text{out}}(g) \rho_{\text{out}}(f)$, since $q(\iota) = e$. Normalisation is immediate; the inner slack dies in $\text{Out}K$. $\square$

Theorem 16 (Band-triviality criterion; Theorem (a)). $\beta = 0 \in H^1(N(\mathcal{C}); \text{Out}K)$ if and only if the transport α is, up to an $\text{Out}K$ -relabelling of objects, inner-valued: iff there is a cocycle $\tilde{\alpha} : \mathcal{C} \rightarrow B(\text{Aut}K)$, cohomologous to α via an $\text{Aut}K$ -valued object relabelling, with $\tilde{\alpha}(f) \in \text{Inn}K$ for every f . In particular, if α already lands in $\text{Inn}K$ then $\beta = 0$; this is the literal “trivial band”, and the theorem says $\beta = 0$ is its gauge-invariant closure.

Proof. ($\Leftarrow$) Let $\tilde{\alpha} = \mu \cdot \alpha$ with $\mu : \text{Ob}\mathcal{C} \rightarrow \text{Aut}K$ and $\tilde{\alpha}(f) \in \text{Inn}K = \ker q$ for all f . Set $\lambda := q \circ \mu : \text{Ob}\mathcal{C} \rightarrow \text{Out}K$. For $f : x \rightarrow y$,

$$\rho_{\text{out}}(f) = q(\alpha(f)) = q(\mu(y)^{-1}\tilde{\alpha}(f)\mu(x)) = \lambda(y)^{-1}q(\tilde{\alpha}(f))\lambda(x) = \lambda(y)^{-1}\lambda(x),$$

so λ trivialises ρ_{out} and $\beta = 0$.

($\Rightarrow$) If $\beta = 0$ there is $\lambda : \text{Ob}\mathcal{C} \rightarrow \text{Out}K$ with $\rho_{\text{out}}(f) = \lambda(y)^{-1}\lambda(x)$. As q is surjective, choose lifts $\mu(x) \in \text{Aut}K$ with $q(\mu(x)) = \lambda(x)$, and set $\tilde{\alpha}(f) := \mu(y)\alpha(f)\mu(x)^{-1}$. Then $q(\tilde{\alpha}(f)) = \lambda(y)\rho_{\text{out}}(f)\lambda(x)^{-1} = e$, so $\tilde{\alpha}(f) \in \text{Inn}K$; and $\tilde{\alpha}$ is a cocycle cohomologous to α via μ . $\square$

This is Giraud stratum 2 specialised to $N(\mathcal{C})$: the band vanishes exactly when the transport is inner-valued up to coboundary. The proof is elementary and Schreier-style, using only the tower ($\star\star$) and the nerve's H^1 . For $K = D_4$ ($\text{Aut} = D_4$ of order 8, $\text{Inn} = (\mathbb{Z}/2)^2$, $\text{Out} = \mathbb{Z}/2$ — both parts non-trivial) over $\mathcal{C} = B(\mathbb{Z})$ the criterion holds for all 8 automorphisms (`scratch/claue_a_D4_check.py`).

Corollary 17 (The full obstruction is staged; Corollary (a')). *A global inventory exists if and only if both (i) $\beta = 0$ (band trivial, Theorem 16) and (ii) $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0 \in H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z)$ (the gerbe class, defined once (i) holds). The obstruction is genuinely staged: $[\mathfrak{g}]$ is defined only after $\beta = 0$, otherwise the stratum-3 coefficients are β -twisted. Thus Theorem 11 is exactly the band-trivial stratum, and Theorem 16 supplies the prior stratum.*

Proof. A global inventory is a relabelling $\mu : \text{Ob}\mathcal{C} \rightarrow \text{Aut}K$ trivialising α outright; projecting by q it trivialises ρ_{out} , forcing $\beta = 0$, so (i) is necessary. Given (i), Theorem 16 makes α inner-valued, $\alpha = \text{conj} \circ \rho$ for $\rho : \mathcal{C} \rightarrow B(\text{Inn}K)$; the gerbe is then the gerbe of lifts of ρ , neutral iff $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$ by Theorem 11. So (i) $\wedge$ (ii) is necessary and sufficient. $\square$

Remark 18 (The band is where the nonabelian content lives). The band is the first obstruction in the program with a *nonabelian coefficient group* $\text{Out}(\text{Aut}F)$. This is an honest structural statement — genuinely different in kind from the abelian H^2 classes — and it is what the earlier “distinguished by its coefficient system” slogan should have said (that slogan was false for $[\mathfrak{g}]$ versus $[\omega]$; Theorem 22). A nontrivial-band witness, with a clean separation of the two strata:

Proposition 19 (A nonvacuous band; Proposition (c)). *Let $K = (\mathbb{Z}/p)^2$ (abelian gauge group of stock) and $\mathcal{C} = B(\mathbb{Z})$ (one reversible/cyclic operation). For abelian K , $\text{Inn}K = 1$ and $\text{Out}K = \text{Aut}K = \text{GL}_2(\mathbb{F}_p)$, so the band sees the entire transport: $\rho_{\text{out}} = \alpha$. Set $\alpha(t) := A$ for some $A \neq I$. Then*

$$H^1(N(B(\mathbb{Z})); \text{Out}K) = \{\text{conjugacy classes of } \text{GL}_2(\mathbb{F}_p)\}, \quad \beta = [A] \neq 0.$$

Moreover the strata separate cleanly: since $N(B(\mathbb{Z})) \simeq S^1$ is 1-dimensional, $H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z) = 0$, so the gerbe class is forced to zero while the band is the sole, nonzero obstruction — living in nonabelian H^1 with coefficients $\text{GL}_2(\mathbb{F}_p)$, prior to and independent of any H^2 story.

Proof. $N(B(\mathbb{Z})) \simeq S^1$; a cocycle is determined by $\rho_{\text{out}}(t) = A$ and object-relabelling by $g \in \text{Out}K$ sends $A \mapsto gAg^{-1}$, so $H^1 = \{\text{conjugacy classes}\}$ and $\beta = 0$ iff $A = I$. For $p = 2$, $\text{GL}_2(\mathbb{F}_2) \cong S_3$; the transvection $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \neq I$ gives $\beta \neq 0$. Clean separation: $H^2(S^1; -) = 0$ for any coefficients (`scratch/band_boundary_verify.py`). $\square$

Interpretation. Stock is defined up to a $(\mathbb{Z}/p)^2$ -gauge (say two independent mod- p ledger offsets); a cyclic refurbishment process t relabels the gauge by a fixed $\text{GL}_2(\mathbb{F}_p)$ element A . If $A \neq I$, no global choice of gauge is consistent around the loop — a *band* obstruction, an outer twist of the structure group, strictly prior to the degree-two gerbe class. Fungibility can never produce it

(Theorem 25); gauge-structured stock does, minimally. Activating both strata at once needs a base with $H^2 \neq 0$ and a nontrivial outer transport (e.g. $\mathcal{C} = B(\mathbb{Z}^2)$, $N \simeq T^2$); the twisted coupling of band to centre on such a base is the natural follow-up and is *not* treated here (Section 9).

6 $[\mathfrak{g}]$ is genuinely a degree-two datum

Theorem 20 (Theorem B). (i) If $|N(\mathcal{C})|$ is homotopy equivalent to a 1-dimensional complex — in particular if $\mathcal{C}$ is the free category on a quiver (a tree-like or DAG supply chain) — then $H^{\geq 2}(N(\mathcal{C}); Z) = 0$, so $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$ for every fibre F . (ii) There is a minimal one-node witness, $\mathcal{C} = B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$ with the fibre a four-lot ring ($K = \text{Aut} F = D_4$), for which $[\mathfrak{g}] \neq 0$.

Proof of (i). If $|N(\mathcal{C})| \simeq X$ with X a 1-dimensional CW complex, then $H^{\geq 2}(N(\mathcal{C}); Z) = H^{\geq 2}(X; Z) = 0$. For the free category $F(Q)$ on a quiver Q , $|N(F(Q))| \simeq |Q|$, a graph; hence $H^{\geq 2} = 0$. It is worth seeing this directly on the reconvergent *diamond* $a \rightrightarrows \{b, c\} \rightrightarrows d$ — the paradigmatic two-route chain — whose nerve is *not* literally 1-dimensional: it carries two nondegenerate 2-simplices, the composites $p; r$ and $q; s$ of the two routes, yet $|N|$ is still homotopy equivalent to a graph. A direct simplicial computation over $\mathbb{F}_2$ (`diamond_nerve_h2.py`) gives chain dimensions $(C^0, C^1, C^2) = (4, 6, 2)$, boundary ranks $\text{rk } d^0 = 3$, $\text{rk } d^1 = 2$, and hence

$$H^0 = 1, \quad H^1 = 1, \quad H^2 = 0, \quad \chi = 4 - 6 + 2 = 0.$$

The lone H^1 is the tier-one reconvergence loop $[\theta_R]$; $H^2 = 0$ says there is no gerbe on a DAG, even one with genuine 2-simplices. $\square$

Proof of (ii). The fibre is four lots arranged in a ring (the 4-cycle); its relabelling group is the dihedral group $K = \text{Aut} F = D_4$ of order 8, with centre $Z = \{1, r^2\} \cong \mathbb{Z}/2$ (the half-turn) and inner group $\text{Inn} K = (\mathbb{Z}/2)^2$. Let $\mathcal{C} = B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$, with reversible operation g ($g^2 = \text{id}$). Choose the inner transport $\rho : B(\mathbb{Z}/2) \rightarrow B(\text{Inn} K)$ sending g to $[r] \in \text{Inn} K$ (the class of the rotation; $[r]$ has order 2 since $r^2 \in Z$). Take the set-section lift $T_g := r$ and $T_{\text{id}} := e$. Then $(\dagger)$ gives

$$\gamma(g, g) = T_g T_g T_{g^2}^{-1} = r^2 T_{\text{id}}^{-1} = r^2 \neq 1 \in Z.$$

Every normalised 1-cochain $c : \text{Mor} \mathcal{C} \rightarrow Z$ has $(\delta c)(g, g) = c_{g^2} c_g^{-1} c_g^{-1} = c_g^{-2} = 1$ (as $Z = \mathbb{Z}/2$ and $g^2 = \text{id}$), so γ is *not* a coboundary and $[\mathfrak{g}]$ is the generator of $H^2(\mathbb{Z}/2; \mathbb{Z}/2) = \mathbb{Z}/2$. The band is trivial here (ρ is inner-valued, so $\beta = 0$), and `inventory_gerbe_h2.py` / the Lean witness [6] confirm $[\mathfrak{g}] \neq 0$. $\square$

Remark 21 (Why not $K = \mathbb{Z}/2$ — homotopy 1-truncatedness is not enough). The earlier version used the *abelian* fibre $K = \mathbb{Z}/2$ on $B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$ and claimed $[\mathfrak{g}]$ was the generator of $H^2(\mathbb{Z}/2; \mathbb{Z}/2)$. This is wrong twice over. First, an abelian fibre carries $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$ by Remark 10 ($\text{Inn} K = 1$, ρ trivial, no lifting gerbe): the group $H^2(\mathbb{Z}/2; \mathbb{Z}/2) = \mathbb{Z}/2$ is nonzero, but the *inventory class* in it is zero. Second, the earlier degree-genuineness hypothesis “ $N(\mathcal{C})$ homotopy 1-truncated” is itself refuted by this very space: $B(\mathbb{Z}/2) = K(\mathbb{Z}/2, 1)$ is 1-truncated, yet $H^2(\mathbb{Z}/2; \mathbb{Z}/2) \neq 0$. The correct hypothesis in (i) is homotopy 1-*dimensionality*. The genuine minimal witness is the nonabelian D_4 of (ii).

Thus $[\mathfrak{g}]$ lives at cohomological degree 2 (nerve level N_3), vanishing on every 1-dimensional chain yet already nonzero on a single reversible loop carrying a nonabelian fibre. For the record, $H^2((\mathbb{Z}/2)^2; \mathbb{Z}/2) = \mathbb{F}_2^3$: $(\mathbb{Z}/2)^2$ hosts three independent $\mathbb{Z}/2$ -gerbes — the D_4 and Q_8 classes and the $\mathbb{Z}/4 \times \mathbb{Z}/2$ class — of which the first were used in Remark 13. (As quadratic forms on $(\mathbb{Z}/2)^2$ there is a single Q_8 class $x^2 + xy + y^2$ and three D_4 classes; a choice of three representatives spanning $\mathbb{F}_2^3$ is x^2 , $x^2 + xy$, $x^2 + xy + y^2$ [6].)

7 Independence from the Zappa–Szép weld

Theorem 22 (Theorem C). *Over the family of pairs (inventory datum, weld datum) on a fixed category $\mathcal{C}$, the gerbe class $[\mathfrak{g}] \in H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); \mathbb{Z})$ and the Zappa–Szép weld $[\omega] \in H^2(\mathrm{Sk}_{\mathcal{C}}; \mathcal{D})$ are logically independent: all four vanishing patterns occur, including $[\mathfrak{g}] = [\omega] \neq 0$. The mechanism is a difference of input data, not of coefficients: $[\mathfrak{g}]$ depends on the inventory fibre F , which is external to $\mathcal{C}$, while $[\omega]$ depends only on $\mathcal{C}$ and a candidate factorisation.*

The quantifier matters, and the earlier “different coefficient systems” explanation was false, so we state the mechanism carefully before proving it. On *some* categories the two classes live in *different* groups (different sites, different coefficients); on others — notably $\mathcal{C} = B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$ — they live in the *same* group $H^2(\mathbb{Z}/2; \mathbb{Z}/2) = \mathbb{Z}/2$ and can be equal. Equal coefficients therefore cannot be what makes them independent. What makes them independent is that they are functions of *different arguments*: fixing $\mathcal{C}$ and varying the inventory fibre moves $[\mathfrak{g}]$ while leaving $[\omega]$ fixed, and varying the factorisation datum moves $[\omega]$ while leaving $[\mathfrak{g}]$ fixed. We exhibit this on a single $\mathcal{C}$.

Proof. Work on $\mathcal{C} = B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$, where both classes can live in $H^2(\mathbb{Z}/2; \mathbb{Z}/2) = \mathbb{Z}/2$. The inventory datum is a fibre F ; take $F \in \{D_4\text{-ring}, \text{pt}\}$, giving $[\mathfrak{g}] \neq 0$ (Theorem 20(ii)) resp. $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$ ($\mathrm{Aut} F = 1$). The weld datum is a candidate Zappa–Szép factorisation of $\mathcal{C}$; take the re-entrant weld of [4], whose class $[\omega] = \varepsilon$ is the generator of $H^2(\mathbb{Z}/2; \mathbb{Z}/2)$, resp. the trivial factorisation $\mathcal{D} = 0$ with $[\omega] = 0$. These two binary choices are independent — one is a function of F , the other of the factorisation — so all four combinations are realised:

on $\mathcal{C} = B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$	weld = trivial ($[\omega] = 0$)	weld = re-entrant ($[\omega] \neq 0$)
fibre = pt ($[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$)	(0, 0)	(0, $\neq 0$)
fibre = D_4 -ring ($[\mathfrak{g}] \neq 0$)	($\neq 0$, 0)	($\neq 0$, $\neq 0$), $[\mathfrak{g}] = [\omega]$

In the bottom-right cell the two classes are *equal* (both the generator of the same group), yet they remain independent as functions: perturbing the fibre to pt kills $[\mathfrak{g}]$ without touching $[\omega]$, and vice versa. Hence neither vanishing implies the other. $\square$

Remark 23 (Not a coefficient discriminator). The earlier claim that “the coefficient system is the only discriminator” and that “there is no natural map comparing $H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); \mathbb{Z})$ with $H^2(\mathrm{Sk}_{\mathcal{C}}; \mathcal{D})$ ” is withdrawn: on $B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$ the two *are* the same group, with the same normalised cocycles, and the comparison map is the identity. The honest statement is the input-data one above. This is why, within the program, we describe $[\mathfrak{g}]$ as distinguished by its *input datum* (the inventory fibre) and not by a coefficient-system discriminator.

Remark 24 (Relation to tier one needs witnesses, not a degree count). It is tempting to argue that the tier-one class $[\theta_R] \in H^1$ and the tier-two class $[\mathfrak{g}] \in H^2$ are “immediately independent because they differ in degree”. That inference is invalid: classes of different degree can be functionally dependent (Bocksteins, cup squares, and d_3 -type differentials all link classes across degrees). Independence of $[\theta_R]$ and $[\mathfrak{g}]$ must be established by witnesses, exactly as for Theorem 22. The full inventory obstruction is a two-tier filtration with associated graded $H^1(N(\mathcal{C}); R)$ (counts) and $H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); \mathbb{Z})$ (relabellings); whether the tiers split or form a Postnikov-type extension (a d_3 coupling $H^1 \rightarrow H^3$) is not determined here (Section 9).

8 When the gerbe is nonvacuous, and fungibility is doubly vacuous

A nonzero gerbe class is a genuine — and slightly surprising — constraint on *which* fibres carry a tier-two obstruction, and the band adds a parallel constraint. Together they make plain fungibility invisible to both.

Theorem 25 (Theorem D). (i) $[\mathfrak{g}]$ can be nonzero only if $K = \text{Aut}F$ is nonabelian with nontrivial centre: $\text{Inn}K \neq 1$ (so ρ can be nontrivial) and $Z \neq 1$ (so the coefficients are nonzero). The minimal such K are D_4 and Q_8 . (ii) For F a bare n -element set of indistinguishable lots, $\text{Aut}F = S_n$: fungible stock carries neither stratum for all $n \geq 3$, $n \neq 6$, since S_n is centreless ($Z = 1 \Rightarrow [\mathfrak{g}] = 0$) and complete ($\text{Out}S_n = 1 \Rightarrow \beta = 0$). The low-order exceptions are disjoint: $n = 6$ is the lone band exception ($\text{Out}S_6 = \mathbb{Z}/2$) and $n = 2$ the lone centre case ($S_2 = \mathbb{Z}/2$) — but S_2 is abelian, so even there $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$ by (i).

Proof. (i) If K is abelian then $\text{Inn}K = 1$, ρ is trivial, and the gerbe of lifts is trivial, so $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$ (Remark 10). If $Z = 1$ then $H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z) = 0$, so $[\mathfrak{g}] = 0$. Thus a nonzero class requires both $\text{Inn}K \neq 1$ and $Z \neq 1$, i.e. K nonabelian with nontrivial centre; the smallest are D_4, Q_8 (order 8). (ii) S_n is complete for $n \neq 2, 6$ (centreless with all automorphisms inner, so $\text{Out} = 1$) and $\text{Out}S_6 = \mathbb{Z}/2$ (Rotman [12], Thms. 7.5–7.7); $Z(S_n) = 1$ for $n \geq 3$, $= \mathbb{Z}/2$ for $n = 2$, $= 1$ for $n \leq 1$. Feed these into (i) and Theorem 16. For $n = 2$, $S_2 = \mathbb{Z}/2$ is abelian, so although the group $H^2(\mathbb{Z}/2; \mathbb{Z}/2)$ is the home of a nonzero class, the *inventory* class is 0 by (i). The exceptional values $n \in \{2, 6\}$ are distinct and each triggers at most one stratum’s coefficient group, as tabulated (scratch/band_boundary_verify.py, out_s6.py). $\square$

The applications boundary is sharp. The nonabelian inventory phenomenon is *invisible to fungibility*: ≥ 3 interchangeable units create no degree-two relabelling obstruction (S_n centreless) and no band obstruction (S_n complete), except the isolated S_6 curiosity. Both nontrivial strata require *gauge/torsor-structured* stock — a fibre whose automorphism group is nonabelian with nontrivial centre (tier-2) or nontrivial outer group (band). This is the economically meaningful regime: allocation defined up to a gauge group K (so $\text{Aut}F = K$ acts by translation, $Z = Z(K)$, Out measuring how the process twists the gauge), not plain interchangeability. The grant headline is exactly this: *fungible inventory carries no nonabelian obstruction; the phenomenon needs structured assets, not commodities*.

9 Scope, open problem, and the two-tier bottom line

Refining inventory comparison from *equality of counts* to *isomorphism of stock-states* raises the consistency obstruction by exactly one categorical level, through a staged obstruction. A global inventory exists iff the band $\beta \in H^1(N(\mathcal{C}); \text{Out}(\text{Aut}F))$ vanishes *and* then the gerbe class $[\mathfrak{g}] \in H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z(\text{Aut}F))$ vanishes (Corollary 17), the latter being the classical Schreier / Eilenberg–MacLane central-extension lifting criterion read as inventory rectification (Theorem 11, Remark 12). The gerbe class is genuinely degree-two, vanishing on every 1-dimensional chain but nonzero already on a single reversible loop $B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$ carrying a nonabelian four-lot ring D_4 (Theorem 20); it is independent of the weld $[\omega]$ by a difference of *input data*, not coefficients — the two can even coincide on $B(\mathbb{Z}/2)$ (Theorem 22); and both strata are invisible to plain fungibility, requiring gauge/torsor-structured stock (Theorem 25). Within the container program this is the fourth distinct H^2 home on $\text{DCont} \simeq \text{Cat}$, after Zappa–Szép holonomy, Ferri prunability, and the Baues–Wirsching class — distinguished by its *input datum*.

The honest open problem. Proposition 19 witnesses a nonvacuous band but does *not* classify nontrivial-band gerbes; that is Giraud’s full nonabelian machinery (the torsor over the twisted $H^2(N(\mathcal{C}); Z)_\beta$), out of scope here. The natural next target is the *coupled* stratum, where band and centre interact: a base with $H^2 \neq 0$ and a nontrivial outer transport, e.g. $\mathcal{C} = B(\mathbb{Z}^2)$ ($N \simeq T^2$) with $K = (\mathbb{Z}/p)^2$ and a commuting outer pair (A, B) , computing the twisted differential d_2 coupling β to the centre class. We do not have this; it is recorded as the PROVE/LEAN follow-up (a bar-complex oracle on T^2). Relatedly (Remark 24), the coupling between tiers one and two — split or Postnikov extension — is stated as a filtration but not computed.

For the grant. The worked economic example to develop is the torsor-fibre case $\text{Aut} F = K$ acting on itself, with $Z = Z(K)$ — gauge-valued allocation, where stock is defined only up to a group action and the tier-two obstruction has real content. The applications payoff of Theorem 25 is that the economically relevant non-rectifiable inventory is not the many-interchangeable-units case but the gauge-structured one; and the band supplies a strictly prior, genuinely nonabelian invariant of the same situation.

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